A persistent poison

DDT (dichloro-diphenyl-trichloroethane) belongs to a group of pesticides called organochlorides. It kills insects on contact by interfering with their nerve impulses. The compound is fat soluble and is deposited in the tissues of animals exposed to it, either directly or by eating contaminated food. Repeated exposure to DDT results in it building up in the body fat and becoming toxic.

DDT also biomagnifies up the food chain. Humans are susceptible to poisoning from regular exposure to DDT and while the effects of small amounts in the environment are unknown, it has been associated with cancer, infertility, miscarriage, and diabetes. It is now banned in western countries, but studies carried out by the US Centers for Disease Control in 2003–4 found DDT or its breakdown product (DDE) in the blood of 99 percent of people tested.

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